

Q How do I take my baby's temperature, and what is a normal reading?

A normal temperature for your baby is around 98.6°F (37°C), with slight variations being usual between children.

If your baby's temperature is higher than 99.5°F (37.5°C), then she has a fever. If your baby is under three months and her temperature reaches 100.4°F (38°C) or higher, or she is under six months with a temperature of 102.2°F (39°C) or more, consult a doctor right away.

Is a fever always a concern?

In babies over six months and toddlers and children, a fever in itself isn't such a great concern, and other signs of illness are used to gauge a child's well-being. In older infants, a raised temperature is actually

a positive sign that her body is fighting off an infection, since it is harder for bacteria and viruses to survive in a hot environment.

Fevers in young babies are less common, and because with young babies it can be harder to spot other signs of illness, or to tell if there is a potentially serious underlying infection, a raised temperature should always be taken more seriously since it may be the only clear sign that something is wrong. You should therefore consult your doctor right away or go to the emergency room (ER) if your young baby has a high temperature and you can't contact your doctor.

TAKING YOUR BABY'S TEMPERATURE

While you may be able to gauge if your baby has a fever by looking at or touching her, taking her temperature lets you know exactly what her temperature is, which is important in young babies. There are several types of thermometer you can use.

THERMOMETER TYPE	DESCRIPTION	
Strip thermometer	Very convenient and easy to use, especially if your baby is fidgety, you just hold the strip on your baby's forehead. However, they are not very accurate because they measure skin, rather than body, temperature.	
Digital underarm thermometer	These are cheap and fairly accurate. Place the bulb of the thermometer under your baby's arm in her armpit, then gently hold her arm alongside her body. You need to hold the thermometer in the armpit for a set amount of time—some beep when they are ready to read. Often the trickiest part of taking a baby's temperature with this type of thermometer is getting her to stay still. Hold and soothe her before you start, and talk to her calmly while you take her temperature. Never place a thermometer in the mouth of a child under five years old.	
Digital ear thermometer	Although more expensive, these take a reading quickly. However, if they aren't placed correctly, they may not be that accurate.	

In the US, young children and babies with a high temperature account for around **20 percent** of the admissions to the children's emergency room (ER) at the hospital.

Q Can a high temperature increase my baby's risk of having a seizure?

Yes, febrile seizures are brought on when a baby or child has a raised temperature. However, although they can look alarming, they are usually harmless. Seizures most often occur between six months and three years old, and are fairly unusual in babies younger than six months old. During a seizure, a baby or child may become stiff, and may lose consciousness and shake her

limbs. If your baby has a seizure, hold her on her side and remove anything from her mouth that she could choke on, such as a pacifier. Make sure her head is turned to the side so that she doesn't choke if she vomits. Stay with her, and time how long the seizure lasts. A baby who has had a first seizure should always be checked by a doctor at the hospital. If your baby has had a seizure before and a subsequent one lasts longer than five minutes, she should be checked by a doctor, and if a subsequent seizure lasts less than five minutes, call your doctor for advice.